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Two Creative Time Zones

Latin America's Cultural Economies in the Agentic Era

An executive briefing for cultural, economic, and trade policymakers across the region — built on UNCTAD 2024 trade data, OECD AI projections, and the Atana AI Exposure × Readiness Index.

Atana — evidence-based AI policy for creative economies in Latin America.

A note from the author

Latin America's creative economies are entering the most consequential decade since the recorded-music boom of the 1960s. The agentic era — the moment when AI systems stop merely advising and start acting on their own — is reordering global value chains around two new scarcities: the speed at which a country can adopt and govern AI, and the authenticity of what its creative producers can offer that machines cannot replicate.

This briefing is the first edition of the Atana Index — an annual reading of where the region stands. It is built on the only original instruments of their kind: the AI Exposure × Readiness Index, calculated from UNCTAD 2024 trade data; and the Two Creative Time Zones framework, which reveals the structural bifurcation underlying the region's creative trade. Both frameworks are open and reproducible.

The conclusions are blunt. Latin America is the region with the lowest responsible-AI maturity in the world. Its creative-services exporters — Brazil, Costa Rica, Uruguay, Colombia — are the most exposed to displacement by foreign AI systems. Its artisanal exporters — Bolivia, Peru, Honduras — face a quieter but equally severe risk: invisibility in agent-mediated discovery channels. There is a three-to-five-year window before regional positions consolidate.

This document is not neutral. It is written for decision-makers who can act in that window.

João Roque
Founder, Atana

Executive Summary

FIVE FINDINGS

1. **Latin America starts behind.** Projected enterprise AI adoption in 2034 is 2–10% in LATAM versus 30–60% in OECD frontier economies (OECD, 2026). The annual income gain from AI is projected at 0.03–0.20 percentage points for LATAM versus 0.4–1.2 p.p. for adopters.
2. **Governance is the binding constraint.** Latin America posts the lowest responsible-AI maturity score globally (2.2/4.0; McKinsey 2026). Only 23% of regional organizations meet level 3 on AI agent governance, against 41% in Asia-Pacific.
3. **The region operates in two creative time zones.** A digital-services bloc (Brazil, Costa Rica, Uruguay, Colombia) faces direct AI displacement risk. An artisanal-goods bloc (Bolivia, Peru, Honduras, Guatemala) faces a quieter risk: exclusion from agent-mediated discovery channels.
4. **Authenticity becomes the scarcest input.** As generic creative content commoditizes toward zero marginal cost, what cannot be replicated by machines — territorial identity, lived heritage, embodied performance — gains value. Latin America has these assets in abundance and undervalues them in its current trade and policy posture.
5. **The window is three to five years.** Frontier countries are setting the rules of agent-mediated cultural commerce now. The cost of catching up after consolidation is structurally higher than the cost of acting before it.

The remainder of this briefing translates these findings into the Atana Strategic Quadrant Map (§5) and four concrete policy lines decision-makers can put into motion this calendar year (§7).

01 The Agentic Inflection

Until 2024, most organizations used AI instrumentally — tools that accelerated existing tasks. From 2025 onward, the inflection becomes qualitative. Agentic systems no longer only advise; they act. They issue autonomous recommendations, trigger actions, interact with other systems, and coordinate end-to-end workflows without continuous human intervention (McKinsey AI Trust Survey, 2026).

For the creative economy, the transition is structurally disruptive for two reasons.

Generic creative content commoditizes toward zero

AI agents can produce text, images, music, and design at near-zero marginal cost. The market for functional content — produced to fulfill a standardized demand — enters accelerated price deflation. The OECD estimates total productivity gains of up to 8–9% over ten years in publishing and audiovisual, which translates into equivalent global price compression (OECD AI Papers No. 57, Fig. 9).

Cultural intermediaries face the Coasian Singularity

Ronald Coase showed that firms and markets exist because coordination and transaction have costs. When AI agents reduce those costs to near zero — searching, comparing, negotiating, delivering — intermediaries who lived by managing that friction lose their reason to be. Galleries, distributors, publishers, licensing agencies: business models anchored in transaction costs that AI is now compressing.

WHAT THIS MEANS FOR CULTURAL POLICY

AI does not destroy creative value. It redistributes it — moving value from those who managed friction toward those who control the customer interface, the behavioral data, or the capacity to orchestrate ecosystems. Cultural policy that focuses only on production support, without addressing distribution and orchestration, will protect the wrong link in the chain.

02 Where Latin America Stands

The OECD models AI adoption along an S-curve, anchored in the historical patterns of general-purpose technologies (electricity, computers, internet, mobile). Applied to Latin America, the model is unforgiving.

Adoption gap

Group	Projected enterprise AI adoption (2034)
Frontier (US, Ireland, Israel, Korea)	**30 – 60%**
Developed Europe	20 – 40%
Latin America (Mexico, Colombia)	**2 – 10%**

Source: OECD AI Papers No. 57, Filippucci et al. (2026), Fig. 4.

Income gap

In the OECD's central scenario, LATAM economies post 0.03 to 0.20 p.p. of annual real income gain from AI — against 0.4–1.2 p.p. for frontier adopters. The gap in domestic adoption is the principal driver, exceeding even the potential advantages from sectoral composition.

Governance gap

Region	Responsible-AI maturity 2025	2026
Asia-Pacific	2.2	2.5
Europe	2.0	2.3
North America	2.1	2.2
Latin America	**1.8**	**2.2**

Source: McKinsey AI Trust Maturity Survey 2026 (n = 496; LATAM sub-sample = 43).

On the specific dimension of AI agent governance, only 23% of LATAM organizations reach level 3 or above, against 41% in Asia-Pacific. This is not merely a technical risk; it is a structural barrier to capturing the technological spillovers that make AI a regional growth engine elsewhere.

03 Two Creative Time Zones

UNCTAD 2024 data, read against OECD adoption projections, reveals that Latin America's creative economy operates in two structurally distinct time zones with respect to the agentic era. They face different risks, different opportunities, and require different policy responses.

Zone 1 — High Digital Exposure

Brazil, Colombia, Costa Rica, Uruguay. These economies export predominantly digital creative services — software, audiovisual, advertising, publishing — and have relatively high capacity for technological absorption. They are simultaneously the most exposed to AI competitive pressure and the best positioned to capture productivity gains if they adopt fast.

Country	Creative services exports (2024, US$ B)	Services share	Atana Readiness Index
Brazil	7.2	84%	**84**
Costa Rica	0.51	97%	74
Uruguay	0.60	98%	73
Colombia	1.28	75%	69

Sources: UNCTADstat 2024 (creative services); Atana Readiness Index (40% services share + 40% log-normalized scale + 20% diversification).

Zone 2 — Concentrated Artisanal Goods

Bolivia, Peru, Honduras, Dominican Republic, Guatemala, El Salvador, Paraguay. These economies export predominantly physical goods — jewelry, textiles, handicraft — with very low direct AI substitution risk (jewelry and textile sectors show less than 2% projected total productivity gain, against 8–9% for digital services).

The risk here is more subtle. A Bolivian silver necklace cannot be generated by an algorithm. But if global buyers use AI agents to discover, evaluate, and acquire cultural products, and those agents work from databases in which Bolivian or Peruvian artisans are not present, verified, or ranked — the physical product simply ceases to be findable.

THE HHI WARNING

Bolivia (HHI = 0.994, 98% jewelry concentration), Dominican Republic (HHI = 0.982, 90% jewelry), and Paraguay (99% craft goods) show extreme export concentration. Concentration amplifies the risk of sectoral shocks — including the entry of digitally generated 'aesthetic jewelry' produced industrially as a low-price competitor.

04 The Authenticity Paradox

There is a contradiction at the center of the AI era that most economic analyses fail to capture.

As AI agents produce generic creative content at industrial scale, scarcity shifts from content to authenticity. What cannot be replicated by algorithms acquires value: specific cultural identity, living memory, the body as instrument, territory as inspiration.

McKinsey articulates this as the logic of structural differentiation: in an AI-reshaped economy, durable value comes not from production efficiency (rapidly commoditized) but from competitive positions anchored in hard-to-replicate assets — proprietary data, network effects, deep customer integration.

For Latin America's creative economies, these assets exist — and are systematically undervalued and under-digitized.

- **Brazil.** One of the world's largest cultural diversities, with internationally recognized music, graphic design, and audiovisual production.
- **Mexico.** Handicraft with unique aesthetic grammars, industrial design with Mesoamerican identity, the largest Spanish-language content market in the world.
- **Peru.** Textile jewelry with centuries of design tradition; viable candidate for cultural Protected Designation of Origin status.
- **Bolivia, Guatemala, Honduras.** Textiles with irreplaceable regional identities — and high vulnerability to digital design-washing.

The problem is not the absence of cultural value. It is the inability to position that value within AI-mediated ecosystems. As product discovery migrates from traditional search to agents that curate, recommend, and negotiate autonomously, producers who are not digitally indexed and verifiable simply disappear from the market.

05 The Atana Strategic Quadrant Map

The 15 mapped countries distribute across four quadrants defined by two indices derived from UNCTAD 2024 data.

- **AI Exposure Index.** Share of (creative services + publications + digital goods) in total creative exports.
- **Readiness Index.** 40% × services share + 40% × log-normalized scale + 20% × diversification (1 − HHI).

Cut points are 40% on both axes. Countries marked † (Mexico, Argentina, Chile) lack reported services data in UNCTAD; their exposure is a lower bound calculated on digital goods alone.

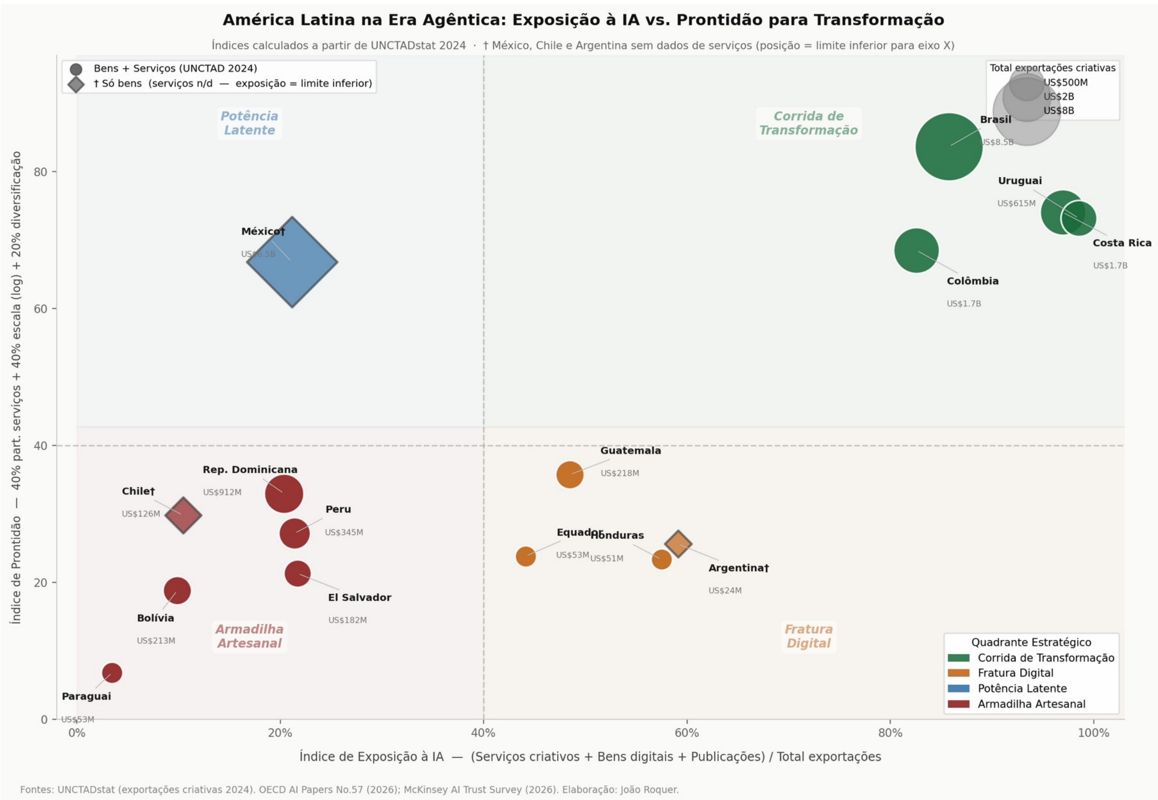

Figure 1 — The Atana Strategic Quadrant Map. 15 LATAM countries by AI Exposure Index (X) and Readiness Index (Y). Bubble size = total creative exports, 2024. Source: UNCTADstat, Atana indices.

The four quadrants

Quadrant I — Transformation Race (high exposure, high readiness)

Brazil, Colombia, Costa Rica, Uruguay. The most exposed economies are also the best positioned to win the agentic transition — if they move fast. The OECD is unambiguous: countries cannot wait for foreign productivity gains without domestic adoption. For these four, speed is strategy.

Quadrant II — Digital Fracture (high exposure, low readiness)

Honduras, Guatemala, Ecuador, Argentina†. Strategically, the most concerning quadrant: high disruption exposure combined with low absorption capacity. Small creative-service exporters risk being substituted by global content-generation platforms before they can consolidate competitive position.

Quadrant III — Latent Power (low measured exposure, high readiness)

Mexico†. The analytically most intriguing case. Mexico holds Quadrant III alone because UNCTAD does not report its creative services. With a creative-goods export volume of US$ 6.5 billion and high diversification, its readiness is genuine — but its true exposure is structurally underestimated. If services data were reported, Mexico would likely migrate to Quadrant I. Today it is a dormant giant.

Quadrant IV — Artisanal Trap (low exposure, low readiness)

El Salvador, Peru, Dominican Republic, Chile†, Bolivia, Paraguay. Predominantly physical creative exports — jewelry, textiles, handicraft — with low structural readiness. AI does not directly substitute these products, but as discovery and curation migrate to agents, artisanal producers without verifiable digital presence become invisible.

Composition of creative exports by AI exposure

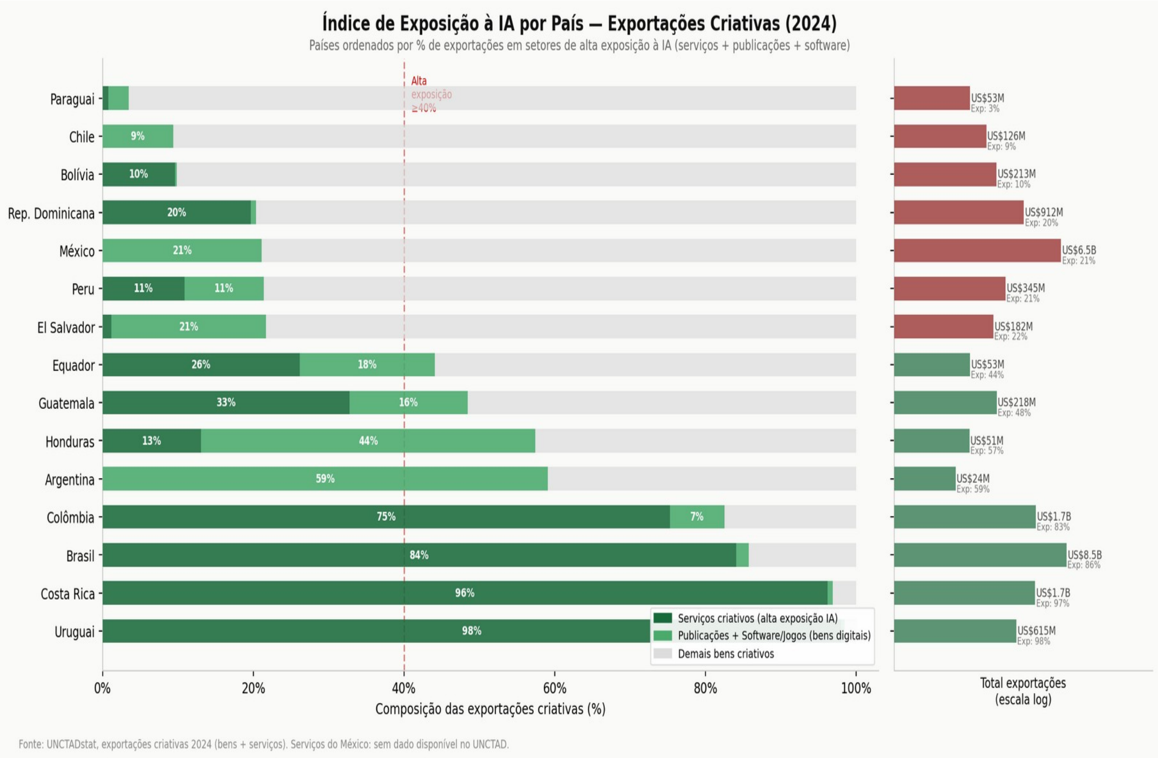

Figure 2 — Composition of creative exports by country and category, ordered by AI Exposure Index. Source: UNCTADstat 2024; Atana indices.

Concentration risk (HHI)

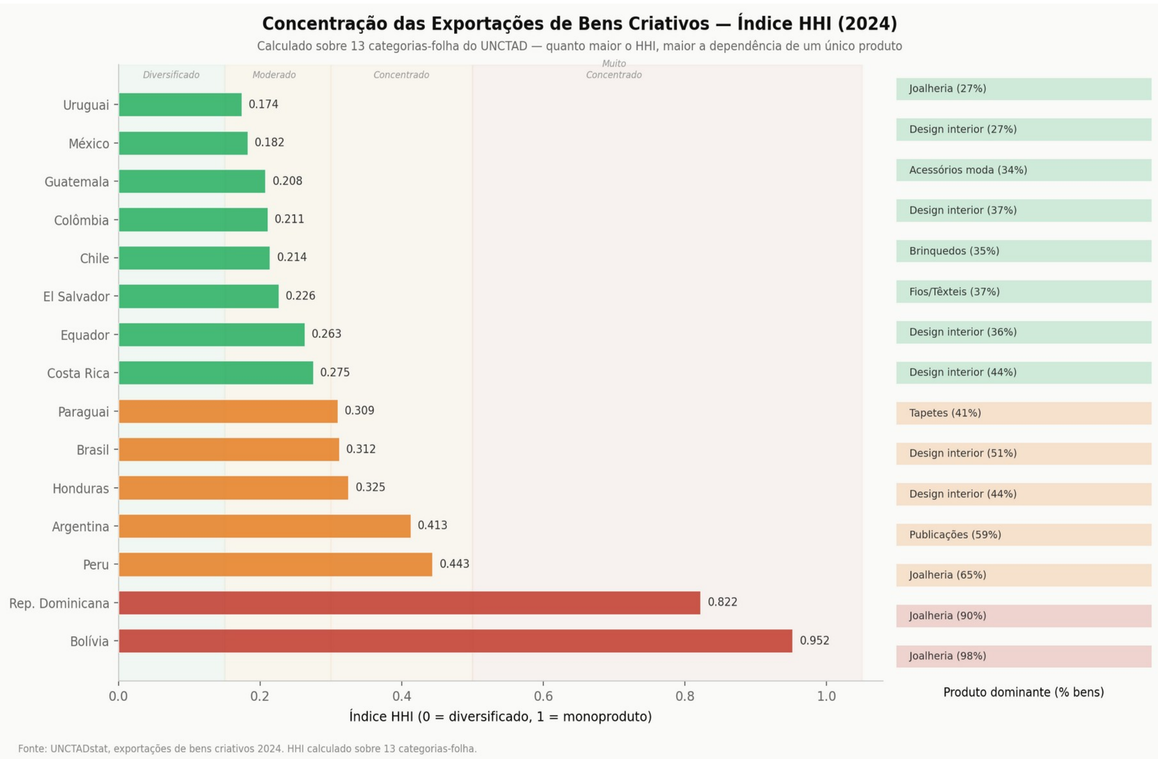

Figure 3 — Herfindahl–Hirschman concentration index (HHI) on 13 leaf categories of creative exports. Higher HHI = greater single-product dependence. Source: UNCTADstat 2024.

06 Three Strategic Bets

Crossing the OECD framework (three transmission channels) with McKinsey's three waves of value creation produces three distinct strategic bets, mapped to country positions in the Atana Quadrant.

Bet 1 — Urgent Domestic Adoption (Zone 1 countries)

For Brazil, Colombia, Costa Rica, Uruguay, and Mexico (probable Q1), domestic adoption is now condition-precedent for export competitiveness. The cultural-sector priority is AI deployment in production and distribution — not only administration — combined with simultaneous investment in AI governance. Intellectual-property risk is the binding consideration: 51% of organizations surveyed by McKinsey rate IP infringement as highly relevant.

Bet 2 — Digital Authenticity Certification (Zone 2 countries)

For Peru, Bolivia, Guatemala, Honduras, and peers, the path is not to compete on digital services. It is to become irreplaceable within AI ecosystems. Three components:

1. **Verifiable indexing.** Structured digital presence (provenance, artisan, technique, geography) in formats agents can read.
2. **Provenance certification.** The cultural equivalent of geographic indications for wine and cheese — anchoring value in unrepeatable origin.
3. **Differentiation narrative.** The artisan's story is the asset that gains value with use, exactly the kind McKinsey identifies as durable in an AI economy.

Bet 3 — Governance as Competitive Advantage (cross-cutting)

McKinsey's 2026 finding that AI trust is increasingly perceived as a business enabler rather than a compliance cost has direct implications for Latin America. Building responsible-AI governance — IP protection, data protection, traditional-knowledge safeguards — is not only risk management; it is the entry condition for international markets that will demand evidence of responsible AI in their creative supply chains.

07 Four Policy Lines for Decision-Makers

The agentic era requires cultural policy to evolve from a posture focused on protection and production support toward one that integrates competitiveness and positioning within AI-mediated ecosystems. Four concrete policy lines emerge from the analysis. None requires a new ministry. All are deployable within current regulatory authority in most LATAM jurisdictions.

POLICY LINE 1

Digital infrastructure for cultural identity. Build national catalog, verification, and indexing systems for cultural goods and creators in formats readable by AI agents — analogous to what the geographic-indications registry already does for agri-food products. Owner: ministry of culture in cooperation with intellectual-property authority. Time to first deployment: 12–18 months. Estimated cost: USD 3–8M depending on national scale.

POLICY LINE 2

Traditional-knowledge protection in the AI context. Explicit regulation on the use of traditional cultural expressions in AI model training, with compensation mechanisms for community holders of that knowledge. Build on existing UNESCO and WIPO frameworks. Owner: ministry of culture and indigenous-affairs authority. Time to first regulatory draft: 6–12 months.

POLICY LINE 3

AI literacy for creative workers. Programs that go beyond tool use to cover how agentic ecosystems work, how cultural products are discovered and ranked by agents, and how to build verifiable digital presence. Owner: ministry of culture in cooperation with labor and education ministries. Pilot scale: 5,000 creators in year 1. Estimated cost: USD 1.5–4M per pilot cohort.

POLICY LINE 4

Responsible-AI maturity inside cultural-sector funding. Progressive integration of AI governance criteria into credit lines and cultural-industry support — particularly IP protection and creator-data protection. Owner: cultural-financing institutions (BNDES, ProColombia, INCAA-equivalents) in coordination with culture ministry. Time to first credit line update: 6–9 months.

08 Methodology and Sources

Data sources

- **UNCTADstat.** Creative goods (US_CreativeGoodsValue) — 2024, USD current, partner = World, flow = exports, 13 leaf categories. Creative services (US_CreativeServ_Indiv_Tot) — 2024. Countries with missing or 'not publishable' values treated as unreported (Mexico, Chile, Argentina).
- **OECD AI Papers No. 57.** Filippucci et al. (2026), 'AI meets trade.' Adoption projections, productivity-gain estimates, and three-channel transmission framework.
- **McKinsey 2026 publications.** AI Trust Maturity Survey (n = 496); 'Where AI will create value — and where it won't'; 'The rise of the human–AI workforce.'

Index definitions

- **AI Exposure Index.** (Creative services + digital goods CER010+CER060 + publications CER030) ÷ total creative exports. For countries with unreported services: lower bound = (digital goods + publications) ÷ total goods.
- **Readiness Index.** 0.40 × services share + 0.40 × log-normalized scale (min = Argentina US$ 24M, max = Brazil US$ 8.55B) + 0.20 × (1 − HHI) × 100. Without services: 0.50 × scale + 0.50 × diversification.

Caveats

- OECD adoption projections for LATAM are entirely modeled (not survey-based), per OECD's own note 52.
- McKinsey LATAM responsible-AI maturity scores are based on 43 organizations within the n = 496 global sample. Small-sample caution applies.
- Mexico, Chile, and Argentina lack reported creative-services data in UNCTAD 2024. Their exposure and readiness in the Atana Quadrant are calculated on digital goods only and are explicitly marked as lower bounds.
- The HHI is calculated on 13 UNCTAD leaf categories (CER021–CER027 instead of CER020 aggregate; plus CER010, CER030, CER040, CER050, CER060, CER070).

About Atana

Atana is a specialized policy advisory practice for the creative economies of Latin America — the only one in the region built on original microdata, two proprietary frameworks (the Two Creative Time Zones and the AI Exposure × Readiness Index), and decade-long depth in the region's cultural-policy infrastructure.

The practice serves national and subnational governments, multilateral organizations, and foundations that need evidence-grounded diagnostics and policy options — not slide decks built on secondary research.

Core engagements

- AI Exposure Diagnostic — country and sector level.
- Creative Workforce Equity Audit — gender, race, formality.
- Public Funding Architecture Review — direct spend, tax expenditures, fiscal incentives.
- Creative Trade Positioning Brief — country positioning in regional creative trade.
- AI Readiness Workshop and Roadmap — capability building.

The Atana Index

This briefing inaugurates the Atana Index — an annual reading of Latin America's creative economy through the AI exposure lens, published open-access in English, Spanish, and Portuguese. Subsequent editions will incorporate updated UNCTAD trade cycles, fresh microdata, and iterations of the underlying frameworks.

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